

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK  
COUNTY OF BRONX

-----X  
DEVONTE SERRANO,

Index No.

Plaintiff,

Plaintiff designates

-against-

Bronx County as the place of trial

CITY OF NEW YORK, individually and in their official  
capacities as New York City police officers, JOSEPH  
BERMUDEZ, RICHARD GIBSON and JOHN or JANE  
DOE 1-10,

The basis of the venue is where the  
injury occurred

**SUMMONS**

Defendants.

-----X  
**TO THE ABOVE-NAMED DEFENDANTS:**

**YOU ARE HEREBY SUMMONED** to answer the complaint in this action and to serve a copy of your answer, or if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance, on the Plaintiff's Attorney(s) within 20 days after the service of this summons, exclusive of the day of service (or within 30 days after the service is complete if this summons is not personally delivered to you within the State of New York); and in case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

Dated: Bayside, New York  
December 30, 2019

  
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**SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP**  
By: Samuel C. DePaola, Esq.  
*Attorneys for Plaintiff(s)*  
42-40 Bell Boulevard - Suite 201  
Bayside, New York 11361  
T: (718) 281-0400

TO: CORPORATION COUNSEL OF THE CITY OF NEW YORK  
100 Church Street  
New York, New York 10007

DET. JOSEPH BERMUDEZ  
Shield #2186, Tax ID #941419  
48<sup>TH</sup> Precinct  
450 Cross Bronx Expressway  
Bronx, New York 10457

LT. RICHARD GIBSON  
Tax ID #899278  
450 Cross Bronx Expressway  
Bronx, New York 10457

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK  
COUNTY OF BRONX

-----X  
DEVONTE SERRANO,

**VERIFIED COMPLAINT**

Plaintiff,

Index No.

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK, individually and in their official  
capacities as New York City police officers, JOSEPH  
BERMUDEZ, RICHARD GIBSON and JOHN or  
JANE DOE 1-10,

Defendants.

-----X  
Plaintiff, Devonte Serrano, by and through the undersigned attorneys, Sim & DePaola,  
LLP, for his complaint against the Defendants, City of New York, individually and in their  
official capacities as New York City police officers, Joseph Bermudez, Richard Gibson and John  
or Jane Doe 1-10, alleges and states as follows:

1. This is a civil rights action, in which plaintiff seeks relief, vis-à-vis 42 U.S.C. §§ 1983, 1985, 1986 and 1988, the common law of the State of New York, in addition to the self-executing clauses or implied private causes of action within the New York State Constitution, for the violations of his civil rights, as guaranteed and protected by the Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States, as well as the Laws and Constitution of the State of New York.
2. The following claims arise from November 14, 2017 incident, in which defendants, acting under color of state law, unlawfully stopped, questioned, searched, arrested and detained Mr. Devonte Serrano, inside of the 48<sup>th</sup> Precinct, located at 450 Bronx Expressway, within the County of Bronx, City and State of New York. Mr. Serrano was subsequently transported from

the 48<sup>th</sup> precinct to Bronx County Central booking. As a result, Mr. Serrano was deprived of his liberty and suffered various physical, emotional and psychological injuries. Mr. Serrano was wrongfully detained for approximately six (6) months when he was released on bail. Plaintiff continued to go to court until October 18, 2018 when all charges against Mr. Serrano were dismissed and sealed.

3. At all times here mentioned, Defendants were acting under color of state law, to wit, under color of the statutes, ordinances, regulations, policies, customs and usages of the City and State of New York.

4. Within 90 of the claims herein, plaintiff timely serve a notice of claim, upon the City of New York.

5. Over 30 days have elapsed since the filing of this notice, and this matter has not been settled or otherwise disposed of.

6. Plaintiff has complied with municipal defendant's request for an oral examination, pursuant to Section 50-H of the New York General Municipal Law and/or the Public Authorities Law and/or no such request was made within the applicable period.

7. This action and associated claims have been timely commenced within all applicable statutes of limitations.

8. Plaintiff seeks monetary damages (compensatory and punitive) against defendants, an award of costs and reasonable attorneys' fees, and such other and further relief as this Court may deem just and proper.

### **PARTIES**

9. Plaintiff, Devonte Serrano ("Mr. Serrano"), presently resides at 1684 Nelson Avenue, Bronx, New York.

10. Defendant, City of New York (“City”), is a municipal corporation organized under the laws of the State of New York.

11. At all times relevant hereto, defendant City, acting through the New York City Police Department (“NYPD”), was responsible for the policy, practice, supervision, implementation, and conduct of all NYPD matters and was responsible for the appointment, screening, hiring, training, supervision, discipline, retention and conduct of all NYPD personnel, including police officers, detectives, investigators, sergeants, lieutenants and other supervisory officers or officials, as well as the individually named NYPD defendants herein.

12. In addition, at all times here relevant, defendant, City, was responsible for enforcing the rules or regulations of the NYPD, and for ensuring that the NYPD personnel obey the laws and constitutions of the United States and the State of New York.

13. Defendant, Joseph Bermudez (“Bermudez”), was, at all times here relevant, a police officer employed by the NYPD and, as such, was acting in the capacity of an agent, servant and employee of the defendant, City of New York. Defendant Officer was, at the times relevant herein, a police officer, under Shield #2186, Tax Reg. No. 941419 assigned to 48 NYPD Precinct Detective Squad, located at 450 Bronx Expressway, Bronx, New York 10457. Defendant Bermudez is being sued in his individual and official capacities.

14. Defendant, Richard Gibson (“Gibson”), was, at all times here relevant, a police officer employed by the NYPD and, as such, was acting in the capacity of an agent, servant and employee of the defendant, City of New York. Defendant Officer was, at the times relevant herein, a lieutenant, under Tax Reg. No. 899278 assigned to 48 NYPD Precinct Detective Squad, located at 450 Bronx Expressway, Bronx, New York 10457. Defendant Gibson is being sued in his individual and official capacities.

15. At all relevant times, defendants John or Jane Does 1 through 10 were police officers, detectives, supervisors, policymakers or officials employed by the NYPD, or City of New York. At this time, Plaintiff does not know the true names or tax registry numbers of defendants, John or Jane Does 1 through 10, as such knowledge is within the exclusive possession of defendants.

16. At all relevant times herein, defendants John or Jane Does 1 through 10 were acting as agents, servants and employees of the City of New York, or the NYPD. Defendants John or Jane Doe 1 through 10 are being sued in their individual and official capacities.

17. At all relevant times herein, defendants were acting under color of state law, to wit, under color of the statutes, ordinances, regulations, policies, customs and usages of the City or State of New York.

#### **FACTUAL CHARGES**

18. On or about, November 14, 2017, at approximately 12:00 p.m., Mr. Serrano was arrested inside the 48<sup>th</sup> NYPD precinct, 450 Cross Bronx Expressway, Bronx, New York, for the alleged Menacing and Assault, of Felix Rodriguez.

19. On or about, November 14, 2017, Defendant Bermudez was assigned to investigate the alleged assault against Felix Rodriguez, which is alleged to have occurred on October 27, 2017, in the vicinity of 1684 Nelson Avenue, Bronx, New York, which led to the arrest and prosecution of the Plaintiff.

20. On or about November 14, 2017, defendant Gibson, was assigned to supervise and assist defendant Bermudez, with the investigation of the alleged assault against Felix Rodriguez, which led to the unlawful arrest and prosecution of the Plaintiff.

21. On or about November 14, 2017, defendants, including defendant Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, unlawfully arrested, handcuffed, seized and searched plaintiff in an excessive manner about his person causing him physical pain and mental suffering.

22. On or about November 14, 2017, defendants, including defendant Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, transferred plaintiff to the detective squad in the 48<sup>th</sup> Precinct where he was illegally questioned and placed in a cell.

23. Plaintiff never committed any crimes or violations of the law, including menacing or assaulting Felix Rodriguez.

24. Defendants, including Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, were fully aware, at all times that they lacked probable cause to arrest Mr. Serrano.

25. Defendants, including Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, lacked probable cause because they used improper and suggestive identification procedures and coercion to unlawfully accuse and arrest Mr. Serrano of a crime defendants knew he did not commit.

26. Defendant Bermudez was Mr. Serrano's arresting officer and signed his criminal court complaint, knowingly and falsely accusing Mr. Serrano of Menacing in the Second Degree and Assault in the First Degree.

27. Defendants, including defendants Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, committed gross deviations from proper police procedure throughout the course of their investigation of Mr. Serrano, namely the failure to properly memorialize witness statements, the failure to properly document their investigation, the withholding and suppression of exculpatory evidence, the use of improper identification procedures, the coercion of witnesses, and the perversion of witness statements to better suit their purpose of arresting and convicting Mr. Serrano for a crime defendants knew he did not commit.

28. Defendants, including defendants Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, failed to disclose, misrepresented and provided false material details, regarding the presence of probable cause, namely the alleged witnesses' false statements and identifications that were procured via illegal tactics.

29. Defendants, including defendants Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, were fully aware, at all times, that the alleged witnesses did not observe Mr. Serrano commit any crimes or violations of the law.

30. Mr. Serrano was held at the precinct for several hours before he was taken to Bronx Central Booking. Mr. Serrano was held in a cell at Central Booking until arraignment 24 hours later, where bail was set.

31. Plaintiff had multiple assaults and batteries, committed to his person, by Defendants, including Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, including but not limited to, being placed in handcuffs too tight.

32. As a result of defendants,' including Bermudez' fabrications, Mr. Serrano was caused to remain unlawfully detained after his arraignment, as well as be subjected to other restrictions placed upon his liberty.

33. Subsequent to his arraignment, Mr. Serrano was transferred to the Vernon C. Bain Correctional Center, also known as "the Boat," in Bronx County, where he remained for approximately six (6) months until he was able to make his bail.

34. Mr. Serrano was forced to return to Court multiple times to face said fraudulent charges, until all charges were dismissed October 18, 2018, which represents a termination of the criminal proceedings in favor of Mr. Serrano.



35. At no point did the defendants, including defendant Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, ever observe Mr. Serrano commit any crime or offense.

36. At no point were the defendants, including Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, ever told by any witnesses that Mr. Serrano committed any crime or violation of the law.

37. The defendants, including defendant Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, had no probable cause or reasonable suspicion to arrest, detain or stop Mr. Serrano.

38. Defendants, including defendants Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, were fully aware that there was no probable cause to believe a prosecution would succeed against Mr. Serrano.

39. Defendants, including defendants Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, knowingly, and intentionally forwarded false, misleading, incomplete and erroneous information, namely that a witness observed Mr. Serrano assault and menace Felix Rodriguez, to prosecutors so that a prosecution would be initiated against Mr. Serrano.

40. Upon information and belief, the NYPD, the City of New York, and their respective policy and decision makers and supervisors have imposed or acquiesced to policies or customs within the NYPD that resulted in Plaintiff's arrest without probable cause.

41. Upon information and belief, the NYPD, the City of New York, and their respective police and decision makers and supervisors have failed to provide adequate training in the identification of probable cause or reasonable suspicion.

42. The instant arrest of Plaintiff without the presence of probable cause was so egregious as to amount to the deliberate indifference by the policy and decision makers within the NYPD and City of New York, because the need for enhanced training and supervision is obvious due to the clear lack of any probable cause to arrest and prosecute Plaintiff.

43. Upon information and belief, further details and factual allegations will become available after discovery is completed, as the current policies and customs of the NYPD and City of New York are within the exclusive knowledge of defendants.

44. Upon information and belief, the personnel files and records of the individual officers involved in Plaintiff's arrest will reveal a history of Constitutional violations that will indicate that defendants City knew, or should have known that the individual officers were unfit for employment as NYPD police officers and would be likely to commit Constitutional violations similar to the violations that were committed against Mr. Serrano.

45. At all times relevant hereto, defendants, including Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, acted maliciously and with intent to injure Plaintiff.

46. At all times relevant hereto, defendants, including Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, were involved in the decision to arrest Plaintiff without probable cause or failed to intervene when they observed others arresting Plaintiff without probable cause.

47. At all times relevant hereto, defendants, including defendants Bermudez, Gibson and John or Jane Doe 1-10, engaged in fraud, perjury, the suppression of evidence and other actions conducted in bad faith, or failed to intervene when defendants observed others doing so, all in furtherance of Plaintiff's criminal prosecution.

48. Plaintiff asserts that the defendants, including Defendants, including Bermudez, Gibson, and John or Jane Doe 1-10, who violated plaintiff's civil rights, are part of a larger pattern and practice of similar misconduct, which is so widespread, pervasive and consistent throughout the NYPD and the City of New York that the commission such constitutionally violative behavior has become tantamount to an official policy or custom within the NYPD and City of New York or, at the very least, conclusive evidence that the City and the NYPD have either tacitly approved

of such egregious wrongdoings or that they have become deliberately indifferent to the civil rights of those who may come into contact with their police officers.

49. The individually named defendants herein, as well as other officers serving in the employ of the NYPD and City of New York, have blatantly, shamelessly, consistently and repeatedly engaged in conduct violative of the civil rights guaranteed and protected by Constitution of the United States, in addition to the laws and Constitution of the State of New York, all without incurring any ramifications for such misconduct and, ostensibly, with the full and complete blessing of the NYPD, the City of New York and their respective policymakers and supervisors.

50. *The New York Times*, as well as numerous other reputable journalistic enterprises, have reported on the widespread corruption within the NYPD and City of New York, particularly the incredibly disconcerting proclivity of many NYPD officers to lie about subject matters that are materially relevant to criminal prosecutions, including the complete fabrication of arrest evidence and witnesses. Also detailed, is the NYPD's obstinate refusal to effectuate corrective or preventive measures to combat the inevitable recurrence of such misdeeds, and perhaps most troubling, the NYPD's alarming tendency to, instead, reward and promote these officers, including those who were inculcated via some incontrovertible form of evidence.

51. On March 18, 2018, *The New York Times* published an explosive article, entitled "Promotions, Not Punishments for Officers Accused of Lying," written by Joseph Goldstein. Mr. Goldstein shines a light on the multitude of flaws within the CCRB and the NYPD, highlighting the fact that the substantiation of a claim against an officer will invariably rely on the presence of incontrovertible proof against the officer. Due to the rarity availability of this type of evidence, an alarmingly small percentage of officer misconduct claims are substantiated. The CCRB is further handicapped by a terribly designed system that requires evidence of a virtually

indisputable nature to substantiate any claim against an officer. The article also details the NYPD's persistent reluctance to investigate or discipline officers who lie and even posits that this reluctance is a significant cause of the lying pandemic within the NYPD. The article references various officers and detectives who were the subject of credible accusations relating to the officers' intentionally false statements, with some allegations coming from federal and state judges.

52. On September 12, 2019, *The New York Times* published another article by Joseph Goldstein, entitled "Officers Said They Smelled Pot. The Judge Called Them Liars." Unsurprisingly, this article dealt with the unusually high frequency of officers using the odor of marijuana to excuse a search that conspicuously does not result in the recovery of any marijuana. It should not require an article in *The New York Times* to call attention to such patently disingenuous tactics, but has become necessary for a variety of reasons, including the NYPD's failure to correct such behavior, the willingness of prosecutors and judges to credit the lying officers and the increasing rate of occurrence.

53. On April 24, 2019, *The New York Times* published an article, entitled "Detective's Lies Sent Three People to Prison, Prosecutors Charge," by Sean Piccolo, detailing the lies of NYPD Second Grade Detective Joseph Franco and how those lies resulted in the imprisonment of at least three innocent people. The article described how Det. Franco lied about observing drug transactions on at least three separate occasions, lies that were only uncovered through contradictory video evidence. Det. Franco's lies resulted in the innocent individuals each being sentenced to prison terms in excess of one-year.

54. Other articles include: (i) "Testilying' by Police: A Stubborn Problem.," by Joseph Goldstein, *The New York Times*, March 18, 2018; (ii) "New York Detective Charged with Faking

Lineup Results,” by Joseph Goldstein, *The New York Times*, February 17, 2018; (iii) “He Excelled as a Detective, Until Prosecutors Stopped Believing Him,” by Joseph Goldstein, *The New York Times*, October 17, 2017; (iv) “Review Board Notes Rise in New York Police Officers’ False Statement,” by J. David Goodman, *The New York Times*, May 14, 2015; (v) “In Brooklyn Gun Cases, Suspicion Turns to the Police,” by Stephanie Clifford, *The New York Times*, December 11, 2014; (vi) “Detective is Found Guilty of Planting Drugs,” by Tim Stelloh, *The New York Times*, November 1, 2011; and (vii) “The Drugs? They Came From the Police,” by Jim Dwyer, *The New York Times*, October 13, 2011.

55. The NYPD has a longstanding and ignominious record of failing to discipline its officers, or even entertaining allegations of wrongdoing against them. On June 26, 2019, *The New York Times* published an article, entitled “2,495 Reports of Police Bias. Not One Was Deemed Valid by the N.Y.P.D.” This article reported that within the last five (5) years, almost 2,500 separate individuals have filed formal complaints with the NYPD alleging that an officer acted with bias toward them, with not a single one being substantiated by the NYPD. Such a finding is plainly incredible and obviously the result of deliberately poor or nonexistent investigatory protocols. The report further impugned the NYPD’s commitment to combat the prejudices and the biases exhibited by many of its officers.

56. Upon information and belief, the NYPD, the City of New York, and their respective policymakers, officials or supervisors have imposed, tacitly approved or acquiesced to policies, customs, or patterns and practices within the NYPD that resulted in plaintiff’s arrest without probable cause.

57. Upon information and belief, the NYPD, the City of New York, and their respective policymakers or supervisors have failed to provide adequate training regarding the identification of probable cause, reasonable suspicion or the appropriate amount of force to be used.

58. Defendants' actions, pursuant to plaintiff's underlying arrest, which occurred without even the semblance of probable cause, were so blatantly violative of plaintiff's civil rights that the tacit approval of identical or similar acts by the policymakers or supervisors of the NYPD and the City of New York, as well as their deliberate indifference towards the rights of any individuals who may come into contact with defendants, should be inferred, because such flagrant deprivations of constitutionally protected rights could not and would not occur without the tacit approval or deliberate indifference regarding the commission of such violations by the policymakers or supervisors of the NYPD and City of New York.

59. Upon information and belief, further details and facts, relating to the unlawful policies, customs or patterns and practices of the NYPD, City of New York and their respective policymakers, supervisors, police officers or employees, will become known after the completion of discovery, as such information is presently within the exclusive possession of defendants, the NYPD and City of New York.

60. Upon information and belief, the personnel files, records and disciplinary histories of the officer defendants will reveal a history of Constitutional violations indicative of defendant City's knowledge that the individual officer defendants were unfit for employment as NYPD officers, or for employment in general, and that the probability of the individually named defendants committing similar violations in the future was extremely high.

61. Upon information and belief, said personnel files, records and disciplinary histories will conclusively show that the City and the NYPD were fully aware of defendants' past

constitutional violations, the unacceptably high probability for the recurrence of similar transgressions, the unreasonably dangerous situations that were likely to result from their hiring or retention, as well as their unsuitability for employment as law enforcement officers, or for employment in general, and that the NYPD and City of New York failed to engage in any preventive or corrective action intended to diminish the likelihood of recurrence for such violations, which is tantamount to the City's tacit approval of such misconduct or the City's deliberate indifference towards the civil rights of those who may interact with its employees, including Bermudez and Gibson.

62. Upon information and belief, the individually named defendants have combined to be named as defendants in numerous lawsuits that have accused them of committing violations similar or identical to those alleged herein.

63. Upon information and belief, the NYPD and City of New York and have failed, or outright refused, to correct the individually named defendants' predilections to engage in unconstitutional behavior or attempt to prevent the recurrence of such misconduct

64. The aforementioned acts of defendants, including the City, Defendants, including Bermudez, Gibson and John Does 1-10, directly or proximately resulted in the deprivation or violation of Mr. Serrano's civil rights, as guaranteed and protected by the Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, as well as the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

65. As a direct or proximate result of said acts, Mr. Serrano was caused to suffer the loss of his liberty, irreparable reputational harm, loss of earnings and potential earnings, physical injury, as well as severe and permanent emotional distress, including fear, embarrassment, humiliation, traumatization, frustration, extreme inconvenience, and anxiety.

**FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION**  
Unlawful Search and Seizure Under  
New York State Law

66. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

67. Defendants subjected plaintiff and his property to unreasonable searches and seizures without a valid warrant and without reasonable suspicion or probable cause do so.

68. Plaintiff was conscious and fully aware of the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person and property.

69. Plaintiff did not consent to the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person or property.

70. The unreasonable searches and seizures to plaintiff's person and property were not otherwise privileged.

71. Accordingly, defendants violated plaintiff's right to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures, pursuant to the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution and Article I, Section 12, of the New York State Constitution.

72. Defendant City of New York, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoings under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

73. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION**  
Unlawful Search and Seizure Under  
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

74. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

75. Defendants subjected plaintiff and his property to unreasonable searches and seizures without a valid warrant and without reasonable suspicion or probable cause do so.



76. Plaintiff was conscious and fully aware of the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person and property.

77. Plaintiff did not consent to the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person or property.

78. The unreasonable searches and seizures to plaintiff's person and property were not otherwise privileged.

79. Accordingly, defendants violated plaintiff's right to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures, pursuant to the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution and Article I, Section 12, of the New York State Constitution.

80. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

### **THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION**

#### **False Arrest and False Imprisonment Under New York State Law**

81. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

82. Defendants subjected Plaintiff to false arrest, false imprisonment, and deprivation of liberty without a valid warrant or probable cause.

83. Plaintiff was conscious of his confinement.

84. Plaintiff did not consent to his confinement.

85. Plaintiff's arrest and false imprisonment was not otherwise privileged.

86. Defendant City of New York, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoings under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

87. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

### **FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

False Arrest and False Imprisonment Under  
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

88. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

89. The Defendants violated the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the U.S. Constitution by wrongfully and illegally arresting, detaining and imprisoning Plaintiff.

90. The wrongful, unjustifiable, and unlawful apprehension, arrest, detention, and imprisonment of Plaintiff was carried out without a valid warrant, without Plaintiff's consent, and without probable cause or reasonable suspicion.

91. At all relevant times, Defendants acted forcibly in apprehending, arresting, and imprisoning Plaintiff.

92. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Assault and Battery Under  
New York State Law

93. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

94. At all relevant times, Defendants caused Plaintiff to fear for his physical well-being and safety and placed him in apprehension of immediate harmful and/or offensive touching.

95. Defendants engaged in and subjected Plaintiff to immediate harmful and/or offensive touching and battered him without his consent or justification.

96. Due to the intentional, willful and unlawful acts of Defendants, Plaintiff suffered damages.

97. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

98. As a direct and proximate result of this breach, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Excessive Force Under  
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

99. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

100. The Defendants violated Plaintiff's rights under the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments, because they used unreasonable force without Plaintiff's consent.

101. Defendants engaged in and subjected Plaintiff to immediate harmful and/or offensive touching and battered him without his consent.

102. As a direct and proximate result of this breach, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Malicious Prosecution Under  
New York State Law

103. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

104. Defendants initiated the prosecution against Plaintiff.

105. Defendants lacked probable cause to believe Plaintiff was guilty or that the prosecution would succeed.

106. Defendants acted with malice, which, in the absence of probable cause, may be inferred.

107. The prosecution was terminated in Plaintiff's favor, when all criminal charges were unconditionally dismissed and sealed.

108. Due to the intentional, willful and unlawful acts of Defendants, Plaintiff suffered significant damages.

109. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

110. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Malicious Prosecution Under  
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

111. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

112. Defendants initiated the prosecution against Plaintiff.

113. Defendants lacked probable cause to believe Plaintiff was guilty or that the prosecution would succeed.

114. Defendants acted with malice, which, in the absence of probable cause, may be inferred.

115. The prosecution was terminated in Plaintiff's favor, when all criminal charges were unconditionally dismissed and sealed.

116. Defendants violated Plaintiff's Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment rights by causing Plaintiff to remain unlawfully incarcerated after his arraignment and trial by jury

117. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**NINTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Malicious Abuse of Process Under  
New York State Law

118. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

119. Defendants arrested, detained and caused a criminal prosecution to be initiated against Plaintiff to compel the compliance or forbearance of some act.

120. Defendants had no excuse or justification to forcibly detain or initiate a prosecution against Plaintiff, especially with the absence of any cognizable probable cause.

121. Defendants intended to inflict substantial harm upon Plaintiff.

122. Defendants acted to achieve a collateral purpose, beyond or in addition to Plaintiff's criminal prosecution.

123. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

124. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**TENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Malicious Abuse of Process Under  
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

125. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

126. Defendants arrested, detained and caused a criminal prosecution to be initiated against Plaintiff to compel the compliance or forbearance of some act.

127. Defendants had no excuse or justification to forcibly detain and initiate a prosecution against Plaintiff, especially with the absence of any cognizable probable cause.

128. Defendants intended to inflict substantial harm upon Plaintiff.

129. Defendants acted to achieve a collateral purpose, beyond or in addition to Plaintiff's criminal prosecution.

130. Defendants' actions deprived Plaintiff of his constitutional rights to free from illegal searches and seizures and to not be deprived of his liberty without the due process of law.

131. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**ELEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Denial of Right to Fair Trial Under  
New York State Law

132. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

133. Defendants fabricated false evidence to be used against Plaintiff that was likely to influence a jury's decision and forwarded said false information to the New York County District Attorney's Office.

134. Defendants' actions deprived Plaintiff of his right to a fair trial and caused post-arraignment restrictions to be imposed on his liberty and freedom of movement.

135. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's right to fair trial, pursuant to the Sixth Amendment to United States Constitution, Article I, Sections 1, 2 and 6 of the New York State Constitution, as well Article II, Section 12, of the New York State Civil Rights Law.

136. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

137. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**TWELFTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Denial of Right to Fair Trial Under  
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

138. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

139. Defendants fabricated false evidence to be used against Plaintiff that was likely to influence a jury's decision and forwarded said false information to the New York County District Attorney's Office.

140. Defendants' actions deprived Plaintiff of his right to a fair trial and caused post-arraignment restrictions to be imposed on his liberty and freedom of movement.

141. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's right to fair trial, pursuant to the Sixth Amendment to United States Constitution, Article I, Sections 1, 2 and 6 of the New York State Constitution, as well Article II, Section 12, of the New York State Civil Rights Law.

142. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**THIRTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Conspiracy to Interfere with Civil Rights and Failure to Prevent the Conspiracy under  
42 U.S.C. §§ 1983, 1985 and 1986 Against Individual Defendants

143. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

144. Defendants engaged in a conspiracy against Plaintiff to deprive Plaintiff of his rights to engage in protected speech or activities, to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures, to be afforded a fair trial, to not be deprived of his liberty or property without due process of law, or of the privileges and immunities under the laws and constitutions of the United States and of the State of New York.

145. Defendants committed overt acts in furtherance of their conspiracy against Plaintiff.

146. As a result, Plaintiff sustained injuries to his person, was deprived of his liberty or was deprived of rights or privileges of citizens of the United States.

147. Defendants' conspiracy was motivated by a desire to deprive Plaintiff of his civil rights or because of some racial, otherwise class-based, invidious or discriminatory animus.

148. The Defendants that did not engage or participate in the conspiracy to interfere with Plaintiff's civil rights, had knowledge that acts in furtherance of the conspiracy were about to be committed or in process of being committed, possessed the power to prevent or aid in the prevention of the conspiratorial objective, and neglected to do so.

149. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's rights, pursuant to the Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and/or Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution.

150. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**FOURTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Failure to Intervene Under  
New York State Law

151. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

152. Those Defendants that were present but did not actively participate in the aforementioned unlawful conduct, observed such conduct, had an opportunity to prevent such conduct, had a duty to intervene and prevent such conduct, and failed to intervene.

153. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

154. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**FIFTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Failure to Intervene Under  
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

155. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

156. Those Defendants that were present but did not actively participate in the aforementioned unlawful conduct observed such conduct, had an opportunity to prevent such conduct, had a duty to intervene and prevent such conduct, and failed to intervene.

157. Accordingly, the Defendants who failed to intervene violated the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments.

158. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**SIXTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Negligent Hiring, Training, Retention and Supervision Under  
New York State Law

159. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.



160. Defendant City owed a duty of care to Plaintiff to adequately hire, train, retain and supervise its employee defendants.

161. Defendant City breached those duties of care.

162. Defendant City placed defendants in a position where they could inflict foreseeable harm.

163. Defendant City knew or should have known of its employee defendants' propensity for violating the individual rights granted under the United States Constitution and the laws of the State of New York, prior to the injuries incurred by Plaintiff.

164. Defendant City failed to take reasonable measures in hiring, training, retaining and supervising its employee defendants that would have prevented the aforesaid injuries to Plaintiff.

165. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**SEVENTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION**

Municipal "*Monell*" Liability Under  
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Defendant City

166. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

167. Defendant City maintained a policy or custom that caused Plaintiff to be deprived of his civil rights, tacitly approved of such violative conduct or was deliberately indifferent toward the potential exposure of individuals, such as plaintiff, to such violative behavior.

168. Defendant City's employee police officers have engaged in an illegal pattern and practice of misconduct, so consistent and widespread that it constitutes a custom or usage, of which a supervisor or policymaker must have been aware of.

169. Defendant City, its policymakers and supervisors failed to provide adequate training or supervision to their subordinates, to such an extent that is tantamount to the City's deliberate

indifference toward the rights of those who may come into contact with defendant City's employees.

170. Defendant City's employees engaged in such egregious and flagrant violations of plaintiff's Constitutional rights that the need for enhanced training or supervision is obvious and equates to a display of deliberate indifference by defendant City and its policymakers toward the rights of individuals, who may come into contact with defendant City's employees.

171. Defendant City's repeated refusal or failure to install or apply corrective or preventive measures constitutes the tacit approval of such violative behavior or a deliberate indifference to the rights of those who may be affected by such behavior.

172. Defendant City's conduct caused the violation of plaintiff's civil rights enumerated within the Constitution of the United States.

173. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

**WHEREFORE**, Plaintiff respectfully requests judgment against Defendants, jointly and severally, as follows:

- a) On the First Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- b) On the Second Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;

- c) On the Third Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- d) On the Fourth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- e) On the Fifth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- f) On the Sixth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- g) On the Seventh Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- h) On the Eighth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- i) On the Ninth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;

- j) On the Tenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- k) On the Eleventh Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- l) On the Twelfth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- m) On the Thirteenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- n) On the Fourteenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- o) On the Fifteenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- p) On the Sixteenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;

- q) On the Seventeenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
  - r) Awarding Plaintiff punitive damages in an amount to be determined by a jury on all causes of action set forth herein;
  - s) Awarding Plaintiff reasonable attorneys' fees and costs pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988;
- Together with the costs and disbursements of this action.

**JURY DEMAND**

Plaintiff demands a trial by jury.

Dated: December 30, 2019

Respectfully submitted,



**SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP**

By: Samuel C. DePaola, Esq.

*Attorneys for Mr. Serrano*

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## ATTORNEY VERIFICATION

I, Samuel C. DePaola, an attorney admitted to practice in the courts of New York State, state that I am a partner with the firm of **SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP**, the attorneys of record for Plaintiffs in the within action; I have read the foregoing and know the contents thereof; the same is true to my own knowledge, except as to the matters therein stated to be alleged on information and belief, and as to those matters I believe it to be true. The reason this verification is made by me and not by Plaintiffs, is because Plaintiffs reside outside the county where deponent maintains his office. I affirm that the foregoing statements are true, under the penalties of perjury.

Dated: Bayside, New York  
December 30, 2019

  
\_\_\_\_\_  
SAMUEL C. DEPAOLA, ESQ.

Index No.:

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK  
COUNTY OF BRONX

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DEVONTE SERRANO,

Plaintiff,

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK, individually and in their official capacities as New York City police officers, JOSEPH BERMUDEZ, RICHARD GIBSON and JOHN or JANE DOE 1-10,

Defendants.

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**SUMMONS AND VERIFIED COMPLAINT**

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**SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP**  
By: Samuel C. DePaola, Esq.  
*Attorneys for Plaintiff(s)*  
42-40 Bell Boulevard  
Suite 201  
Bayside, New York 11361  
Tel. (718) 281-0400

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To: CORPORATION COUNSEL OF THE CITY OF NEW YORK

*Attorney(s) for Defendants*

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Service of a copy of the within is hereby admitted.

Dated:

Attorney(s) for